



Big-ticket attraction: Sachin Tendulkar with Dallas Cowboys owner Jerry Jones (second from left), Arun Agarwal, Chairman of the National Cricket League and the Texas Economic Development Corporation (second from right), and Charlotte Jones (right). AP

shaped how Charlotte thinks about India. Frisco and the wider North Texas region now have a large Indian-origin population, including many families who have moved directly from India, and Charlotte sees sport as one of the easiest ways for those worlds to meet.

"There is a huge Indian population here," she says. "There are kids over here in high school that have never picked up a football helmet. They don't even know what that is. And there are kids here that don't know what a cricket bat is." For Charlotte, that exchange is not just a marketing opportunity but a cultural one. "Sport is the way to do that," she says. "A way for communities to learn each other through the games they bring with them."

That may be the most revealing part of the Cowboys' rise. Charlotte does not speak about fandom as a series of transactions to be optimised. She speaks about it as belonging. "Our game has always been a respite for people," she says. "Everybody gets up, they work hard, they go to work, they have their own problems, and then for three hours they get to leave their problems behind, come to the game or watch

it on television and relate to something else." The value of that, she believes, lies not simply in the action on the field but in the emotional life around it.

"The success of our game has been the shared memory," she says. "That's the emotional connection you make with your family, friends, who you're watching with. You're sharing in the drama."

It is why she returns so often to the idea that sport is one of the few places left where strangers can still feel part of the same thing. "I've always felt that the value of sport is to bring people together," she says. "You sit by somebody you didn't know when you first sat down, and by the end of the game you're either hugging them or you're crying. You're either sad or you're happy, but now you've connected."

That belief shapes how she thinks about community investment. "We spend as much time, energy, effort and money investing into the community as we do into the players that play the game and the venues that host them," she says. "It shows you care first, and then it works. It becomes trust." In many ways, that is the real business model of the

Cowboys. The sponsorships, media rights, merchandising and real estate matter enormously, but underneath them sits a simpler proposition where the franchise has to become part of people's lives in a way that survives results on the field. It must feel less like a team you watch and more like a place you belong.

That is also why the World Cup has felt so natural in Dallas. For a month, the Cowboys' home has been transformed into a meeting point for supporters from Latin America, Europe, Africa and Asia. Argentina shirts, Norwegian Viking chants, Egyptian flags and first-time visitors have all passed through a venue built, in Charlotte's mind, not simply to host games but to host people.

For Charlotte, that is the legacy she hopes this World Cup leaves behind in North Texas.

"I hope the legacy is about the kindness and openness of our people," she says. "We want you to come here. We want to show you around. We want to help you. We want to support you. We don't need anything back. We just want you to love it here." It is a characteristically Texan vision of hospitality, but also one that fits the broader Cowboys project. To make the stadium feel less like a venue you pass through and more like a place that invites you in.

And for an Indian audience, perhaps that is where Tendulkar comes back into the story. What Charlotte recognised in him was not just fame, but permanence. The way a sporting figure can come to stand for memory, ritual and inheritance.

It is the same kind of permanence the Cowboys have spent decades trying to build around themselves. Not just a successful team, but an institution people carry with them as part of who they are.

That, more than a championship count, is the scale on which Charlotte Jones thinks. And it may be the clearest explanation of why, even in a World Cup summer dominated by football, one of the tournament's defining venues still feels unmistakably like the home of the Dallas Cowboys.